

are in, there is a pole long enough to pull you out. It really is not that difficult, and I will map out the game plan for you.

The First Step

The potential lender or credit card company or bank does not look at you, the person, in your dapper new suit, all clean shaven with a fresh hair cut. You may go to your house of worship every weekend, volunteer at the charity pancake breakfast, and be a fine, upstanding, model citizen in every way, shape, and form. Maybe you can even do a handstand and walk it the length of Main Street. Impressive as that might be, they, the lenders, only look at your credit report and your credit score. You need to get a copy for yourself so you know what they are looking at and how they are judging you. Most importantly, you need to make sure that what is on the report is accurate.

What exactly is the credit report and credit score? The short answer is that these are the tools that the creditor or lender uses to assess your creditworthiness. Are you a good risk? Will you pay on time? An exact score is calculated, landing at a result between 300 and 850. How and why it is this range, I do not know. Rating on a scale of one to ten would be too easy, I guess.

Simply put, the credit report and credit score make up your financial reputation, in black and white, on a piece of paper. If your score is considered too low, a credit card company can deny you. With the way that they operate today, more than likely, they will be happy that you have a low score so they can give you a credit card and charge you a higher interest rate. They want you to have a lower score so that they can get more fees out of you. In fact, the system is designed so that you continue to have a lower credit score. Frightening, but true. We will go over all these details so you understand exactly what is happening, what the lenders are up to, and what you can do about it.

Credit Reporting Agencies

There are three national bureaus that keep credit reports on the good people of America. If you have any credit transaction at all, in any state, you have a credit history, and they have a credit report on you. The agencies are Experian, TransUnion, and Equifax. Their addresses